

DAY 7: LOWER THE COST OF CAR REPAIRS

Ahhh...cars. Unless you live in the middle of a great big city, it's rare to meet a person without one. In fact, I can't imagine how different and much smaller our world would be without cars. I'll be the first to admit that I absolutely love the freedom and flexibility I get from owning my own vehicle, and how quickly it gets me to and from the store. Plus, it's fun to pack the trunk and speed off on a spontaneous road trip every once in a while!

But until you own a car for yourself, you never truly understand what a pain they are to manage, maintain, fill up, and repair. It doesn't matter whether you buy used or brand new—cars are not built to last more than a few decades, and those years are often filled with financial stress as we replace part after part to keep them running. It's no wonder cars are considered one of the worst investments you can ever make.

Joseph and I try to head off some of the more expensive repairs by keeping a little bit extra stashed away for those rainy days, but once that “domino effect” starts, it's hard to stop. One year we had a substantial tax return that we were thrilled to put towards a down payment on our first house. But right after we deposited the check, our transmission died, and that money we had been so excited about saving went straight to the local mechanic instead.

While I'm thankful we had that money when we did, it's proof that cars are very expensive pieces of equipment to maintain. However, I'm not about to give up my license to drive, or sell the very thing we use almost every day...are you? That means we have to figure out how to keep our vehicles as low maintenance (and inexpensive) as possible.

Since I'm not a car expert by any means, I peppered Joseph with questions about how we can save more on car maintenance and repairs. He was full of great advice, and here are the six ideas we came up with:

1. FIND A REPUTABLE REPAIR SHOP